Gartner

First Take: Datadog Moves Observability Platforms Toward Autonomous Operations

10 June 2026 - ID G00858398 - 4 min read

By: Padraig Byrne, Dylan Roberts, Colin Fletcher, Andre Bridges

Initiatives: Delivery of Functional Responsibilities; Reinvent I&O as an Enabler of AI Value

Heads of I&O and their teams had their growing interest in autonomous operations capabilities affirmed by Datadog's recent DASH announcements. However, mature governance and guardrails will be vital to protecting your operations instead of causing chaos.

Overview

Key Findings

- **Datadog's unified AI-driven loop responds directly to market demands.** Buyers expect **observability platforms** to move away from predefined monitoring and take active corrective action across the entire operational loop.

- Strict guardrails remain the decisive trust layer despite these new capabilities. Organizations must mandate explicit approval workflows and service-based policies to safely extend autonomy and manage growing observability cost sensitivity.

- Operations roles must shift from executing remediation to supervising and auditing agents. This far-reaching change remains a major hurdle for which most I&O teams are completely unprepared.

Recommendations

- **Pilot autonomous detection and remediation** in low-risk domains like resource exhaustion and certificate expiry before extending to revenue-critical services.
- **Define explicit guardrails, approval gates and rollback procedures** before granting any agent write access to production; treat these controls as nonnegotiable procurement criteria.
- **Redesign on-call and SRE roles around agent supervision.** Assign explicit ownership to codify operator and organizational knowledge into machine-readable runbooks and memory stores that agents can consume.
- **Demand evidence of remediation accuracy, explainability, auditability and failure behavior from vendors.** Benchmark agent actions against human baselines.

Analysis

Observability Is Evolving Toward Autonomous Operations

On 9 June 2026, Datadog announced the unification of the "Autonomous Ops Loop" via Bits Detection, Memories, and Remediation at the DASH conference. [1] This release marks another step towards moving beyond a focus purely on the behavior of systems. The future of IT operations demands autonomous platforms that natively detect, investigate and correct issues. However, if you deploy these agentic, self-healing systems without mature governance and strict policy guardrails, you invite operational chaos.

> **To prevent catastrophic failure loops, you must mandate strict approval workflows before granting AI agents direct write access to your production environments.**

Look Beyond the Product to Mitigate Lock-In Risk

Datadog continues to lead the observability market because it prioritizes ease of use for buyers facing an explosive increase in operational telemetry. Human-centric operations constantly struggle in rapidly changing environments where software complexity can multiply hourly. Autonomous detection systems must step in to establish dynamic baselines because manually configured alerts will inevitably fail.

While this announcement reinforces Datadog's usability advantage, products alone will not guarantee your success. You will likely need additional training and professional services to fully operationalize these agentic capabilities, as detailed in our related Forecast Analysis. [2]

Furthermore, multiple vendors currently support autonomous closed-loop systems. You must treat this adoption decision as a comparative exercise and evaluate at least one alternative platform to mitigate significant platform stickiness and severe vendor lock-in risk.

Use Guardrails to Direct AI Remediation

Autonomous detection is only the starting point. The true value and risk of this market transition lie in autonomous remediation. When you grant **AI agents** direct write-access and execution privileges to scale, restart and patch critical infrastructure, you greatly increase the potential for catastrophic failure loops.

For instance, an agent executing automated database restart at the wrong time could easily amplify a minor performance issue into a full-scale outage. Guardrails, like Datadog's implementation based on metadata that identifies a certain system, environment or service, are simply not optional.

Trusted Context Is Your Ultimate Bottleneck

Operational data quality and contextual hygiene remain the primary bottlenecks to making autonomous remediation reliable. AI agents cannot safely troubleshoot on raw telemetry alone. You must ground them in historical human operator context like past postmortems, configuration changes and implicit, tacit knowledge. Without these contextual memories, your agents will rely on generic large language model assumptions. This inevitably leads to inaccurate or dangerous troubleshooting decisions.

Transform SREs & IT Ops From Responders to Governors

Ultimately, this transition redefines the role of your site reliability engineers (SRE) and IT operations. Instead of spending hours in calls manually interpreting telemetry patterns, your future SREs will act as operational governors, data curators and policy directors. Their primary responsibility must rapidly shift from executing runbooks to defining strict behavioral boundaries, reviewing agent decisions and curating the high-fidelity operational datasets that feed AI memories.

Evolve or Fall Behind AI-Driven Complexity

While a cautious, crawl-walk-run approach is necessary to establish internal trust, ignoring **autonomous operations** is no longer a viable plan. Enterprises that successfully adopt and govern these closed-loop architectures will achieve massive improvements in reliability and scalability. Conversely, organizations that insist on manual remediation will continue to fall behind under the crushing burden of AI-driven complexity.

Evidence

[1] Datadog Launches 100+ Capabilities to Help Customers Drive Autonomy and Manage Growing AI and Security Complexity Datadog.

[2] Forecast Analysis: Agentic AI in IT Operations Management Software, Gartner.

Evolving Insights History

Table 1: Evolving Insights History

Published Date ↓	*Update* ↓
10 June 2026	Initial Publish

Recommended by the Authors

Some documents may not be available as part of your current Gartner subscription.

Forecast Analysis: Agentic AI in IT Operations Management Software

Table 1: Evolving Insights History

Published Date	*Update*
10 June 2026	Initial Publish